

NEW ZEALAND MIXED FOREST

Remnants of vast tree cover provide evergreen oases

Aligned almost south-north, and 1,000 miles (1,600 km) long, New Zealand straddles considerable latitude and experiences a wide temperature range as a consequence. The annual average is below 50°F (10°C) in the far south, yet nearly double this at the northern tip. Since the country's greatest width is 250 miles (400 km), nowhere is far from the Pacific Ocean. The result is a cool-to-warm, generally moist climate where temperate forests thrive.

Main forested regions

On South Island, the Richmond temperate forests cloak the northeast. The damper west becomes more rugged southward, through the Westland temperate forest ecoregion to the Fjordland National Park alpine zone in the far southwest. In the far north of North Island is the flatter, milder Northland temperate kauri forests. These mixed forests are home to many kinds of indigenous

conifers, such as the totara, rimu, and giant kauri—all in the pine group—as well as silver, red, black, and hard beeches. The majority of these trees are evergreen, so the forest floor remains in shade all year, with a dense understory of mosses, ferns, and small shrubs.

Much unique New Zealand wildlife thrives in these forests, from grasshopperlike wetas, to the bold kea and flightless kakapo parrots and ground-based kiwis. Before humans arrived, mixed temperate forests covered more than three-quarters of New Zealand. Burning, logging, and conversion to agriculture mean that today only a quarter remains.



NEW ZEALAND PIGEON

SEED STIMULATION
Certain trees, such as the rimu, depend on a few native animal species, including New Zealand pigeons, to distribute their seeds. The seeds must pass through the birds' gut and be expelled in droppings before they can germinate.

SNAILS IN PERIL
Unique to New Zealand forests, fist-sized amber snails—a type of land snail—are carnivores, feeding on earthworms. However, introduced possums, rats, hedgehogs, and other animals have devastated their numbers.

AMBER SNAIL

New Zealand is home to more species of flightless bird



BRUSHTAIL POSSUM

PLAGUE POSSUMS
To launch a fur trade in the 1830s, brushtail possums were introduced from Australia. These omnivorous marsupials have been a disaster for New Zealand's native ecology, damaging trees and eating eggs, insects, snails, and even bats.

Kauris may live for 1,500 years